

The Full On-Page Audit

Everything in Tier 2, compressed into a repeatable pass you can run on a site you have never seen.

Bottom line

This section turns Sections 11 to 19 into one ordered process with a time budget. Run it on your own site, then run it on a stranger's in sixty minutes. Being able to do that reliably is the difference between knowing the tactics and having the skill.

The order, and why

Audit in the order that finds the biggest problems first, so that if you run out of time you have still found what matters.

- 1 **Intent match** (Section 4). If intent is wrong, nothing below matters.
- 2 **Cannibalization** (Section 8). Two pages fighting is worse than either page's problems.
- 3 **Content quality and evidence** (Section 14). The substance.
- 4 **Titles and descriptions** (Section 11). Fastest measurable win.
- 5 **Headings and structure** (Section 12). Retrieval and scannability.
- 6 **Internal linking** (Section 16). The unused lever.
- 7 **E-E-A-T signals** (Section 18). Cheap credibility.
- 8 **Media** (Section 17). Weight and alt text.
- 9 **URLs** (Section 13). Note only, rarely change.
- 10 **Decay and pruning** (Section 19). What to remove.

Note that the fast, satisfying fixes sit in the middle. Resist starting there.

The 60-minute site-level pass

Minutes 0 to 10: orientation

- What does this site sell, to whom?
- `site:domain.com` for a rough page count
- Search Console access if available. Without it, you are inferring rather than diagnosing, and you should say so
- Identify the 5 to 10 pages that should matter commercially

Minutes 10 to 20: intent and cannibalization

- For each priority page, search its main query. Does the page type match what ranks?
- `site:domain.com <topic>` for the top 3 topics. Multiple pages covering the same ground?
- In Search Console, filter by top queries and check whether several URLs pick up impressions for each

Minutes 20 to 35: content and metadata

- Read the top 3 pages properly. Do they answer the query in the first 60 words? Is there evidence? First-hand experience? Would a reader stop searching?
- Check titles against 50 to 60 characters and front-loading. Compare to what actually displays in the SERP
- Check meta descriptions exist and are specific
- Check heading structure: one H1, no skipped levels, headings that answer things
- Sort Search Console by impressions and find the high-impression, low-CTR pages

Minutes 35 to 45: linking and credibility

- Count internal links to the priority pages
- Run `site:` searches for missed internal link opportunities
- Check for orphans
- Check About page, contact details, named authors, HTTPS

Minutes 45 to 55: media and technical surface

- PageSpeed Insights on the two most important pages, note LCP and what element it is
- Spot-check alt text
- Note obvious URL problems without recommending changes

Minutes 55 to 60: prioritize

- Three things to fix this week
- Three things to fix this month
- One thing that is structural and needs a real decision

The output

An audit that lists forty problems is not useful. An audit that names the three that matter is.

Structure the deliverable as:

- 1. The one-line diagnosis.** What is actually wrong. "The content is fine, the titles are filing labels and the pages are orphaned" is a diagnosis. "Several SEO issues were found" is not.
- 2. The three highest-impact fixes,** each with the evidence that supports it and the expected effect. Be honest about the expected effect, including when it is small.
- 3. What is fine.** Genuinely useful and almost always omitted. It tells the reader you looked rather than pattern-matched, and it stops them changing something that works.
- 4. The structural question,** if there is one. "Your service pages and blog target the same queries" is a decision the owner needs to make, not a task you can hand them.

What separates a good audit

It is prioritized. Impact ordered, not checklist ordered.

It is evidenced. Every claim points at a report, a screenshot, or a SERP.

It is honest about uncertainty. "I cannot tell without Search Console access" is a legitimate finding.

It distinguishes floors from levers. From Section 3: Core Web Vitals, mobile and HTTPS are floors. Telling someone already passing to optimize further is telling them to waste money.

It does not pad. Twelve findings, ten of them trivial, is padding. It is also the standard output of most automated audit tools, which is why an audit that is just a tool export has no value.

The tool trap

Screaming Frog and Semrush site audits will hand you a list of hundreds of issues. Most are noise. The tool cannot tell you that a page targets the wrong intent, that two pages cannibalize, or that content is thin.

Use tools for the countable things: broken links, redirect chains, missing tags, page weight. **Use judgement for everything that matters.** The judgement is the deliverable.

Why this matters

the ability to look at an unfamiliar site and say what is actually wrong in an hour is the most portable skill in this course. It is what you sell, it is what makes proposals credible, and it is what separates an SEO from someone who runs an audit tool and forwards the PDF.

Do this now

- 1 Run the full 60-minute pass on your capstone site.** Time yourself honestly.
- 2 Write the four-part output:** one-line diagnosis, three highest-impact fixes, what is fine, and the structural question.

- 3 Compare against your Section 1 notes.** You wrote naive observations before you knew any of this. The gap between those and today's audit is the clearest measure of what you have learned.
- 4 Now audit a site you have never seen.** A competitor, a friend's business, anything. Sixty minutes, same output.
- 5 Note where you ran out of time.** That tells you which step you are slowest at.
- 6 Execute your three this-week fixes** on the capstone site.

Capstone step

Tier 2 is complete. Your capstone site has been through a full content audit with a prioritized output, and you have run the same pass on an unfamiliar site under time pressure. Tier 3 moves underneath the content to the technical layer, where you will find the things quietly capping everything you just improved.

Key takeaways

- Audit in impact order: intent, cannibalization, content, then metadata, structure, links, credibility, media, URLs. The satisfying fixes are in the middle, so resist starting there.
- The deliverable is a one-line diagnosis, three prioritized fixes, what is fine, and the structural question. Forty findings is padding.
- Say what is working. It proves you looked and stops people breaking something that works.
- Tools count things. They cannot tell you a page targets the wrong intent or that two pages compete. The judgement is what you are actually selling.